



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Estancia Valley Classical Academy
School Website: <https://theevca.com/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Estancia Valley Classical Academy (EVCA) presents a clearly classical orientation across most rubric categories, anchored in a classical liberal arts framework, virtue formation, and a pedagogy that foregrounds traditional classical methods. Public materials show a mission-and-culture built around character formation, the liberal arts tradition, and a deliberate emphasis on a great-books oriented curriculum and Socratic-style pedagogy. Evidence from EVCA's own materials points to a strong alignment with the classical aim of forming virtue and wisdom rather than merely imparting information, with explicit references to classical pedagogy (Schol , Socratic dialogue, memorization/recitation) and a governance structure steeped in parental and community involvement. Still, some categories reveal room for stronger explicit articulation of theology, liturgical/community practices, and explicit faculty modeling as a "living curriculum." Overall, EVCA is best categorized as CLASSICAL, with a few areas that are SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully classical in the published materials.

Key takeaways by category (bottom-line classification): - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (virtue-oriented, but limited explicit theological or liturgical framing in public materials) - School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL (formation of virtue and wisdom, human flourishing, pursuit of truth) - Curriculum: CLASSICAL (liberal arts emphasis, Great Books orientation implied, integration across disciplines) - Pedagogy: CLASSICAL (Socratic dialogue, Schol , memorization/recitation, imitation and practice) - Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (public materials emphasize teachers as mentors and the role of faculty, but explicit "living curriculum" framing is not clearly documented in the accessible extracts) - Parents & Community: CLASSICAL (founded by parents and community; ongoing parent/community engagement through governance and open channels)

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public EVCA materials foreground virtue, character, and moral formation within a classical framework, including explicit mentions of virtues and habits of character (honesty, discipline) and a mission oriented toward the classical liberal arts.
 - The materials do not show a robust, explicit theology or liturgical framework in the public-facing text, though classical education literature cited by EVCA includes theological and transcendent themes in the broader classical lexicon. This limits the category to somewhat classical rather than fully classical.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: virtue, moral formation, character, habits of character, honesty, discipline.
 - Negative keywords present: none clearly evidenced in public materials (no explicit secular ethics or value-neutral framing shown in the extracts). The absence of theology-liturgical framing keeps this within "SOMEWHAT."

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- Why this rating
 - The school clearly aims at virtue and character, aligning with transcendental aims of classical education, but lacks explicit theological and liturgical articulation in the accessible public materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL placement rather than fully CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - EVCA positions education as formation and cultivation of virtue and wisdom, not simply information or job-ready training. The founders describe a mission to provide a content-rich, rigorous classical liberal-arts education aimed at forming character and excellence.
 - Mission statements emphasize fidelity to the classical tradition and “habits of character” as part of education, signaling a telos oriented toward truth, goodness, and the beautiful.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, human flourishing, great conversation (implicit in Great Books/moral discourse), classical mission, virtue ethics.
 - Negative keywords present: minimal explicit emphasis on workforce/job-readiness; public materials do not foreground “career-ready” as the primary aim. Some elements (e.g., a later College & Career event) appear, but they don’t dominate the stated telos.
- Why this rating
 - The school’s stated purpose emphasizes formation and virtue within the classical liberal-arts framework, aligning with the classical aim of human flourishing and the pursuit of truth. While college/career preparation is incidental (evidenced by events like a College & Career Fair), it does not appear as the primary goal in the public mission statements. This justifies CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Curriculum language explicitly references the liberal arts tradition and classical scope, including humanities, history, philosophy, and sciences; the school frames its curriculum around a classical liberal-arts education. The Founders describe an education in “humanities, languages, history, government, geography, and the first principles of philosophy” and sciences in math and natural philosophy, with arts including visual arts and music.
 - Public materials repeatedly tie EVCA to classical education norms: Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books/Great Conversation, and integrated history-laden inquiry implied by a cross-disciplinary approach, as discussed in the broader classical lexicon used by EVCA.
 - Pedagogy section reinforces alignment with traditional classical curriculum modalities (recitation, memorization, and canonical/historic texts via classical methods).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium: arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), Great Books/Great Conversation, history integrated with literature/philosophy, interdisciplinary unity, wonder/holy integration.
 - Negative keywords present: none in public text signaling a departure from classic curriculum norms (no explicit project-focused or purely STEM-first framing as a dominant approach). The public descriptions align strongly with classical content and approach.
- Why this rating
 - EVCA’s curriculum statements and public materials align with core classical curriculum tenets (Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books, interdisciplinary integration, wonder, and unity of truth/history/philosophy). This warrants CLASSICAL positioning for Curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- Pedagogy section explicitly names Socratic dialogue and dialectic, Scholé (restful learning), memorization/recitation (singing/chanting, memory work), and formation through imitation and practice; upper-level rhetoric, speech, and debate opportunities are noted. This directly mirrors classical pedagogy expectations.
- The public materials describe lower-school practices (singing/chanting, memory work) and upper-school structures (Socratic discussions, seminars, debates), which match the classical pedagogical progression from memory work and contemplation to argumentation and rhetoric.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue, Scholé (restful learning), recitation/memorization, singing/chanting, imitation, masterful rhetoric, speeches, seminars, and debates.
 - Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials; no overt emphasis on purely experiential, constructivist, or project-based-only pedagogy in these extracts.
- Why this rating
 - The school's pedagogy map aligns closely with classical teaching methods (Socratic, memorization/recitation, restfulness, and rhetoric). This justifies CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - There are explicit references to teachers as the core of the school and to governance and mission that imply teacher modeling of virtue and skill, with a visible focus on “the living curriculum” in classical settings generally referenced by classical models. However, explicit wording in EVCA's public materials about teachers as “living curriculum” or as “model teachers and mentors” is not directly quoted in the accessible extracts; the presence of a staff directory and administration pages suggests active faculty involvement central to school life.
 - Founders' narrative emphasizes formation and character in teachers' and leaders' roles, and governance includes community/parent involvement, suggesting a living, mentoring culture rather than a purely disciplinary or transactional faculty model.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty as core, teacher as exemplar (implied by mission language and classical framing).
 - Negative keywords present: explicit statements of “faculty as living curriculum” and detailed teacher-profile portraits are not robustly shown in the extracts; some classical markers exist but not in a fully explicit, codified way (e.g., a formal “portrait of a teacher” or explicit faculty formation program).
- Why this rating
 - EVCA demonstrates strong classical sensibilities in terms of faculty roles and mentorship implicitly through mission and pedagogy, but the publicly accessible materials do not present a fully explicit, codified “living curriculum” faculty framework. This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - EVCA's founding explicitly states that the academy was created by parents and community members who sought a rigorous classical education for their children, signaling deep parental and community involvement from inception. The governance model (Governing Council) and open channels further indicate ongoing parental engagement and transparency.
 - Public materials show ongoing family involvement and parent inclusion in school processes (e.g., contact channels, governance references). The presence of parent-focused narratives and the charter status reinforces community-anchored governance and partnership with families.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental engagement, home-school collaboration, open campus/inclusion of families in school life.

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- Negative keywords present: none evident in the extracts; the school’s own materials foreground family partnership and community involvement rather than consumer/customer standpoints.
 - Why this rating
 - The public materials strongly reflect a classical ethos of family partnership and community integration, which aligns with the “Parents and Community” category as CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Assessment

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL
 - The strongest category alignment is Pedagogy and Curriculum, with Purpose/Goal and Community showing clear CLASSICAL orientation, and Religious Foundations and Faculty showing substantial classical alignment with some room for strengthening explicit theological framing and living-curriculum articulation. The aggregate supports a CLASSICAL designation.

What Would Move the Needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL areas)

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations) needle-movers:
 - Public articulation of theology or sacred dimension integrated with classical studies (e.g., a formal statement of theology as a Mistress Science) and explicit liturgical/community practices embedded in the school culture.
 - Produce a published section describing liturgical rhythm, sacred music, or congregational practices that connect Virtue with a metaphysical framework.
- Element 5 (Faculty) needle-movers:
 - Provide explicit language in public materials describing the faculty as the living curriculum, with portraits or profiles of teachers that show virtue, professional formation, and mentorship approaches; include teacher development aligned with classical pedagogy (e.g., seminars, master-teacher models).

Note: No additional sections are required beyond these needle-movers given the overall CLASSICAL standing. The school’s category-wide alignment already supports a CLASSICAL classification, with targeted enhancements as above.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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